The Critical Dispatch

VOL. 1, NO. 052

2026-03-30

FRONT PAGE

dbVar August 2020 Release

PubMed Health

d bVar August 2020 Release

Summary:

August dbVar data release New/updated studies: 2 New Variant regions: 63836 New Variant calls: 66248 Non-Redundant Deletions: 2,535,364 Non-Redundant Duplications: 428,062 Non-Redundant Insertions: 1,310,643

dbVar Resources:

Study Browser Human Data Hub Organism List FTP files Tools for analyzing dbVar data Non-Redundant Structural Variants

New/updated studies:

Study: nstd102 (Clinical Structural Variants) Publication: See individual variant records for publications Description: Structural Variants with clinical assertions, submitted to ClinVar by external labs. dbVar now imports all placements from ClinVar as “submitted” and only remaps what is missing in order to place all variants on both GRCh37 and GRCh38. See Variant Summary counts for nstd102 in [dbVar Variant Summary|/dbvar/content/var_summary/#nstd102]. See the latest statistics for nstd102 in [Summary of nstd102 (Clinical Structural Variants)|/dbvar/content/clinvar_summary]. Organism: Human(9606) Study Type: Case-Set Submitter: ClinVar (NCBI) Variant Calls: 65134 Variant Regions: 62722 FTP: https://ftp.ncbi.nlm.nih.gov/pub/dbVar/data/Homo_sapiens/by_study

Study: nstd194 (Lee et al 2020)

Description: To systematically identify non-reference insertion structural variants among human populations, we

developed an insertion detection pipeline, InserTag, which generates unmapped contigs by local

de-novo assembly and then infers the full-sequence of insertion variants by tracing the contigs

from non-human primates and other human assemblies. By application of the pipeline to 1000 Genomes

Project database, we could identify 1,696 non-reference insertion variants in 2,535 individuals and

re-classify the variants as retention of ancestral sequences or novel sequence insertions based on

the ancestral state. Here, we report 1114 variants which are larger than 100 bp and have genotypes.

See Variant Summary counts for nstd194 in [dbVar Variant

Summary|/dbvar/content/var_summary/#nstd194].

Organism: Human(9606)

Study Type: Collection

Submitter: Jin-young Lee (Yonsei University)

Variant Calls: 1114

Variant Regions: 1114

FTP: https://ftp.ncbi.nlm.nih.gov/pub/dbVar/data/Homo_sapiens/by_study

See the latest statistics for nstd102 in [Summary of nstd102 (Clinical Structural Variants)|/dbvar/content/clinvar_summary].

PubMed Health

FEATURES

Build 136: FTP update for build specific SQL files for non-human organisms

PubMed Health

The SQL files below have been updated on dbSNP FTP site for the following organisms.

Arabidopsis (taxid 3702)

Chimpanzee (taxid 9598)

Macaque(taxid 9544)

Nematode (taxid 6239)

Pig (taxid 9823)

Rat (taxid 10116)

Orangutan (taxid 9601)

Zebrafish (taxid 7955)

The build specific files (b136_*) were missing from the regular build dumps and have been restored for each organism.

Base FTP URL - ftp://ftp.ncbi.nih.gov/snp/organisms/

./arabidopsis_3702/database/organism_data

./arabidopsis_3702/database/organism_data/b136_ContigInfo_101.bcp.gz

./arabidopsis_3702/database/organism_data/b136_ContigInfo_101.bcp.gz.md5

./arabidopsis_3702/database/organism_data/b136_MapLinkInfo_101.bcp.gz

./arabidopsis_3702/database/organism_data/b136_MapLinkInfo_101.bcp.gz.md5

./arabidopsis_3702/database/organism_data/b136_MapLink_101.bcp.gz

./arabidopsis_3702/database/organism_data/b136_MapLink_101.bcp.gz.md5

./arabidopsis_3702/database/organism_data/b136_SNPChrPosOnRef_101.bcp.gz

./arabidopsis_3702/database/organism_data/b136_SNPChrPosOnRef_101.bcp.gz.md5

./arabidopsis_3702/database/organism_data/b136_SNPContigLoc_101.bcp.gz

./arabidopsis_3702/database/organism_data/b136_SNPContigLoc_101.bcp.gz.md5

./arabidopsis_3702/database/organism_data/b136_SNPContigLocusId_101.bcp.gz

./arabidopsis_3702/database/organism_data/b136_SNPContigLocusId_101.bcp.gz.md5

./arabidopsis_3702/database/organism_data/b136_SNPContigProtein_101.bcp.gz

./arabidopsis_3702/database/organism_data/b136_SNPContigProtein_101.bcp.gz.md5

./arabidopsis_3702/database/organism_data/b136_SNPMapInfo_101.bcp.gz

./arabidopsis_3702/database/organism_data/b136_SNPMapInfo_101.bcp.gz.md5

./arabidopsis_3702/database/organism_data/b136_SNPMapLinkProtein_101.bcp.gz

./arabidopsis_3702/database/organism_data/b136_SNPMapLinkProtein_101.bcp.gz.md5

./arabidopsis_3702/database/organism_schema

./arabidopsis_3702/database/organism_schema/arabidopsis_3702_constraint.sql.gz

./arabidopsis_3702/database/organism_schema/arabidopsis_3702_index.sql.gz

./arabidopsis_3702/database/organism_schema/arabidopsis_3702_table.sql.gz

./chimpanzee_9598/database/organism_schema

./chimpanzee_9598/database/organism_schema/chimpanzee_9598_constraint.sql.gz

./chimpanzee_9598/database/organism_schema/chimpanzee_9598_index.sql.gz

./chimpanzee_9598/database/organism_schema/chimpanzee_9598_table.sql.gz

./macaque_9544/database/organism_data

./macaque_9544/database/organism_data/b136_ContigInfo_101.bcp.gz

./macaque_9544/database/organism_data/b136_ContigInfo_101.bcp.gz.md5

./macaque_9544/database/organism_data/b136_MapLinkInfo_101.bcp.gz

./macaque_9544/database/organism_data/b136_MapLinkInfo_101.bcp.gz.md5

./macaque_9544/database/organism_data/b136_SNPContigLoc_101.bcp.gz.md5

./macaque_9544/database/organism_data/b136_SNPContigLoc_101.bcp.gz

Apple's Assault on Standards

Alex Russell (infrequently noted)

TL;DR : Market competition underlies the enterprise of standards. It creates the only functional test of designs and lets standards-based ecosystems route around single-vendor damage. Without competition, standards bodies have no purpose, and neither they, nor the ecosystems they support, can retain relevance. Apple has poisoned the well through a monopoly on influence, which it has parleyed into suppression of browser choice. This is an existential threat to the web, but also renders web and internet standards moot. Internet standards bodies should recognise the threat and respond.

Internet enthusiasts of the previous century sometimes expressed the power of code by declaring the sovereignty of cyberspace, or that "code is law."

As odd as these claims sound today, they hit a deep truth: end-users, and even governments, lack power to re-litigate choices embodied in software. Software vendors, therefore, have power. Backed by deeply embedded control chokepoints , and without a proportional response from other interests, this control is akin to state power.

Both fear and fervour about these properties developed against a backdrop of libertarian 1 attitudes toward regulation and competition. Attenuating vendor power through interoperability was, among other values, a shared foundation of collaboration for internet pioneers.

The most fervent commitment of this strain was faith in markets to sort out information distribution problems through pricing signals, 2 and that view became embedded deeply into the internet's governance mechanisms. 3 If competition does not function, neither do standards.

The internet's most consequential designs took competitive markets as granted. Many participants believed hardware and software markets would (and should) continue to decouple; that it would be easier for end-users to bring their own software to devices they owned. It is odd from the perspective of 2025 to suggest that swapping browsers, e.g., should come at the cost of replacing hardware. This is why Apple have worked so hard to obscure that this is exactly the situation it has engineered, to the detriment of users, the web, and internet standards.

Internet standards bodies assumed the properties of open operating systems and low-cost software replacement to such an extent that their founding documents scarcely bother to mention them. 4 Only later did statements of shared values see fit to make the subtext clear.

And it has worked. Internet standards have facilitated interoperability that has blunted lock-in, outsized pricing power, and other monopolistic abuses. This role is the entire point of standards at a societal level, and the primary reason that competition law carves out space for competitors to collaborate in developing them. 5

But this is not purely an economic project. Standards attenuate the power of firms that might seek to arrogate code's privileges. Functional interoperability enables competition, reallocating power to users. Standardisation is therefore, at least partially a political project; one that aligns with the values of open societies:

We must ask whether ... we should not prepare for the worst leaders, and hope for the best. But this leads to a new approach to the problem of politics, for it forces us to replace the question: "Who should rule?" by the new question: "How can we so organize political institutions that bad or incompetent rulers can be prevented from doing too much damage?"

— Karl Popper, "The Open Society and Its Enemies"

Without a counterweight, network effects allow successful tech firms to concentrate wealth and political influence. This power allows them to degrade potential competitive challenges, enabling rent extraction for services that would otherwise be commodities. This mechanism operates through (often legalised) corruption of judicial, regulatory, and electoral systems. When left to fester, it corrodes democracy itself. 6

Apple has deftly used a false cloak of security and privacy to move the internet, and the web in particular, toward enclosure and irrelevance. Cupertino acts as a corrupted, and indeed incompetent, autocrat in our digital lives, even for folks who don't carry iPhones. It accomplishes this trick through abuse of a unique monopoly, allowing it to extract rents, including on the last remnants of open ecosystems it tolerates.

Worse, Apple's centralisation through the App Store entrenches the positions of peer big tech firms, harming the prospects of competitors in turn. Apple have been, over the course of many years, poisonous to internet standards and the moral commitments of that grand project. 7

Standards are voluntarily adopted and success is determined by the market.

Despite near continuous horse-race coverage in the tech

Becoming America

Throughline (NPR)

When the United States of America was founded, it was only a union of a small number of states. By the beginning of the 20th century, the United States had become an empire; with states and territories and colonies that spanned the globe. As a result, the country began to not only reconsider its place in the world, but also its very name.

dbVar December 2020 Release

PubMed Health

d bVar December 2020 Release

Summary:

December 2020 Release New/updated studies: 4 New Variant regions: 95356 New Variant calls: 103281 Non-Redundant Deletions: 2,563,576 Non-Redundant Duplications: 433,664 Non-Redundant Insertions: 1,308,484

dbVar Resources:

Study Browser Human Data Hub Organism List FTP files Tools for analyzing dbVar data Non-Redundant Structural Variants

New/updated studies:

Study: nstd186 (NCBI Curated Common Structural Variants)

Description: A curated dataset of all structural variants in dbVar that meet the following criteria: were part

of a study with at least 100 samples; included allele frequency data; had an allele frequency of

become available. See Variant Summary counts for nstd186 in [dbVar Variant

Summary|/dbvar/content/var_summary/#nstd186]. See the latest statistics for nstd186 in [Summary of

nstd186 (NCBI Curated Common Structural Variants)|/dbvar/content/common_summary].

Organism: Human(9606)

Study Type: Control Set

Submitter: NCBI dbVar Curated (NCBI)

Variant Calls: 61086

Variant Regions: 55981

FTP: https://ftp.ncbi.nlm.nih.gov/pub/dbVar/data/Homo_sapiens/by_study

Study: nstd194 (Lee et al 2020)

Publication: Lee et al. 2020

Description: To systematically identify non-reference insertion structural variants among human populations, we

developed an insertion detec-

IN BRIEF

PubMed Health, PubMed Health: The following journal has been added to the PubMed Central archive: Journal Title: Canadian Urological Association Journal ISSN: 1911-6470 (print) URL: http://www.pubmedcentral.nih.gov/tocrender.fcgi?action=archive&journal=552 Archive includes: v. 1 (2007) to the present. There is no embargo delay for this journal.

PubMed Health, PubMed Health: NHLBI TOPMed: Determining the Association of Chromosomal Variants with Non-PV Triggers and Ablation-Outcome in AF (DECAF) (study page | release notes)

PubMed Health, PubMed Health: NIH RECOVER: A Multi-Site Observational Study of Post-Acute Sequelae of SARS-CoV-2 Infection in Adults (study page | release notes)

PubMed Health, PubMed Health:

The PubMed journals translation table has been updated to include journal names without initial articles such as: the, le, la, a, an, etc. This means that such journal titles can now be searched with or without initial articles and they will map to the appropriate journal.

PubMed Health, PubMed Health: Genomic Data Archive From the Network for Pancreatic Organ Donors With Diabetes (study page

|

release notes)

PubMed Health, PubMed Health: The following new journal from Hindawi has been added to PubMed Central: International Journal of Endocrinology ISSN: 1687-8337 (print) 1687-8345 (electronic) http://www.ncbi.nlm.nih.gov/pmc/journals/995/ Archive includes: v. 2009(2009). Note: There is no embargo delay for this title.

PubMed Health, PubMed Health: The following new journal from Medknow Publications has been added to PubMed Central: Ancient Science of Life ISSN: 0257-7941 (print); 2249-9547 (electronic) URL: http://www.ncbi.nlm.nih.gov/pmc/journals/1769/ Archive includes volume 1 (1981) to volume 30 (2011) Note: There is no embargo delay for this journal.

PubMed Health, PubMed Health: The following new journal from SAGE-Hindawi has been added to PubMed Central: Autoimmune Diseases ISSN: 2090-0430 (electronic) http://www.ncbi.nlm.nih.gov/pmc/journals/1390/ Archive includes: v. 2010(2010) Note: There is no embargo delay for this title.

PubMed Health, PubMed Health: The [illegible]

We The People: Canary in the Coal Mine

Throughline (NPR)

The Third Amendment. Maybe you've heard it as part of a punchline. It's the one about quartering troops — two words you probably haven't heard side by side since about the late 1700s.

At first glance, it might not seem super relevant to modern life. But in fact, the U. S. government has gotten away with violating the Third Amendment several times since its ratification — and every time it's gone largely unnoticed.

Today on Throughline's We the People : In a time of escalating political violence, police forces armed with military equipment, and more frequent and devastating natural disasters, why the Third Amendment deserves a closer look.

What Happened After Civilization Collapsed

Throughline (NPR)

What happens after everything falls apart? The end of the Bronze Age was a moment when an entire network of ancient civilizations collapsed, leaving behind only clues to what happened. Today, scholars have pieced together a story where everything from climate change to mass migration to natural disasters played a role. What the end of the Bronze Age can teach us about avoiding catastrophe and what comes after collapse.

The Critical Dispatch

Vol. 1, No. 052 · 2026-03-30

Curated and composed automatically.